

Magic BALLOT

It was an experiment in Kerala that changed the country's democratic process, confining the ballot paper to history and redefining the electoral process

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

Over a quarter century ago, a little experiment in democracy began in Kerala's tiniest assembly constituency Parur, with just 80,144 voters. The move to introduce it across the country was short-circuited by the Supreme Court which ruled that the law had to specifically provide for the use of electronic voting machines (EVMs) in elections.

Cut to the Lok Sabha polls of 2004 when nearly 390 million voters across the country green-lit candidates on nearly 1.3 million machines. In India's first all-electronic elections, results beeped in, in just four hours. Overnight, the ballot paper, rubber stamp and purple ink joined the junkyard of typewriters and rotary dial phones as anachronisms. A handful of constituencies still use paper ballots, reminders of a plodding past where it took an army of requisitioned Central government staff up to 40 bleary-eyed hours to physically count votes. It was also a somewhat dubious blood and ink-splattered history that contributed words like booth capturing to the lexicon.

Theoretically, goons can still capture EVM booths and repeatedly punch in their candidates to electronically rig the election. But Election Commission (EC)

3,840

is the number of votes an EVM can record. It takes one minute to record five votes.

5,000

metres above sea level, Anlay Phoo, near Leh, is the highest polling station

